

# Presentation Notes V2

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## Question 5

a) Discuss aspects that one should be aware of when dealing with different cultures in a professional context in order to work together successfully, e.g. as a representative of a company and negotiating partner or as colleagues working together or as in a relationship employee or employer.

### 1. Hierarchy and Deference (Employer-Employee Dynamics)

#### • **Cameroon (Visible, Decisive Authority):**

- The Hierarchy: Power distance is relatively high. Employees expect leaders to provide clear, assertive direction, with status being highly visible and verbally reinforced through formal titles (e.g., “Director,” “Chief,” “Manager”).
- The Management Risk: Taking a purely flat, overly casual approach as an employer can easily be misinterpreted as a lack of direction or professional competence.
- The Deep Cultural Root (Beneath the Iceberg): High power-distance norms where a leader’s visible authority provides psychological safety, clarity, and structural order to the collective workforce.

#### • **Sri Lanka (Quiet & Institutional Deference):**

- The Hierarchy: Respect for authority is deeply internalized, heavily influenced by traditional social structures and spiritual frameworks. Decisions flow strictly from the top down, and employees rarely challenge a boss openly.
- The Management Risk: Taking a quiet, deferential environment at face value can be misleading; an employer must never mistake a colleague’s quietness for automatic agreement.
- The Deep Cultural Root (Beneath the Iceberg): Karmic and spiritual frameworks where respecting hierarchical elders preserves cosmic and social harmony, making overt defiance culturally unthinkable.
- Professional Takeaway: Do not mistake authority styles for absolute consensus. In both cultures, challenging a leader publicly is seen as deeply disrespectful. Employers must actively design private, subtle feedback channels rather than expecting open contradiction in a big meeting.

### 2. High-Context Communication and "Saving Face" (Colleague Collaboration)

#### **Cameroon (Expressive Diplomacy):**

- The Communication Vibe: Relational and highly expressive. While indirectness is strategically used to maintain workplace harmony, day-to-day professional interactions remain generally vocal, warm, and energetic.
- The Handling of Dissent: Open conflict is strictly kept away from public view. Disagreements are rarely handled via cold, public emails; instead, they are resolved through warm, face-to-face interpersonal diplomacy.
- The Deep Cultural Root (Beneath the Iceberg): Relational collectivism. Preserving the warmth of the face-to-face human connection is prioritized over raw, clinical efficiency.

#### • **Sri Lanka (Soft-Spoken Preservation of "Face"):**

- The Communication Vibe: Exceptionally polite and gentle. Professional interactions are strictly non-confrontational, prioritizing the quiet preservation of personal and collective “face.”

- The Handling of Dissent: Direct rejection is entirely avoided. A straightforward “No” is practically nonexistent in a corporate environment, substituted instead by soft, diplomatic phrases like “I will look into it” or “It might be difficult.”
- The Deep Cultural Root (Beneath the Iceberg): Societal harmony and shame-avoidance. Damaging someone’s “face” in public fractures the social fabric, so protective politeness is legally and socially enforced in text and speech.
- **Professional Takeaway:** Leave “brutal honesty” at the door. When collaborating as colleagues in either environment, public criticism will instantly derail a project. If a timeline is falling behind, always address the issues privately and frame the problem entirely around the task rather than the person.

### 3. Relationship-Driven Trust vs. Transactional Agendas (Negotiation)

- **Cameroon (Kinship and Community Trust):**
- The Trust Dynamic: Business operates strictly on networks of mutual trust and personal alignment . A Cameroonian partner wants to know your character, background, and long-term commitment before getting to transactional details.
- The Negotiation Pace: Rushing straight into contract details without establishing a personal bond creates suspicion and stalls progress.
- The Deep Cultural Root (Beneath the Iceberg): Traditional communal survival dynamics, where a legal piece of paper is considered secondary to the moral character of the person signing it.
- **Sri Lanka (Patience and Protocol):**
- The Trust Dynamic: Negotiations are highly deliberate, formal, and slow. Building trust involves navigating multi-generational, family-owned conglomerates or deeply embedded institutional frameworks.
- The Negotiation Pace: Showing visible impatience or trying to force a quick closure signals a severe lack of respect for their established protocols and organizational hierarchy.
- The Deep Cultural Root (Beneath the Iceberg): Long-term orientation and risk-aversion. Decisions require layered consensus across a collective network to avoid shame or unstable business commitments.
- Professional Takeaway: People come before paperwork. As a company representative, allocate the first portion of your interaction entirely to relationship-building. Treat social lunches, tea ceremonies, or informal chats not as “wasted time,” but as the actual foundation upon which the legal contract stands.

### 4. Navigating Internal Cultural Sub-Blocs (Company Representative)

- **Cameroon (The Bi-Systemic Split):**
- The Internal Divide: A unique administrative and cultural split between the Anglophone (North-west/Southwest) and Francophone (the remaining eight regions) territories.
- The Operational Impact: This directly dictates entirely different legal frameworks (Common Law vs. Civil Law), distinct bureaucratic styles, and polarized regional corporate expectations.
- The Deep Cultural Root (Beneath the Iceberg): Colonial history. Dual post-colonial legacies have left deeply rooted institutional behaviors that shape how professionals expect systems to operate.
- **Sri Lanka (The Linguistic Link):**
- The Internal Divide: A corporate landscape that requires a highly sensitive balance between the majority Sinhala and minority Tamil communities.
- The Operational Impact: Corporate communication handles this friction by utilizing English as the official “Link Language” in professional spaces.

- The Deep Cultural Root (Beneath the Iceberg): Historical ethno-linguistic tensions. English acts as a politically neutral, frictionless equalizer, ensuring no group feels culturally marginalized in the corporate environment.
- Professional Takeaway: Do not apply a single blanket strategy. When designing company policies, localizing branches, or sending representatives, explicitly acknowledge these internal administrative and linguistic structures to ensure your business operations feel fair, inclusive, and legally sound to the local workforce.